

Finding Victims of the 1834 and 1842 Mob Attacks in the Archives

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Main Article

The most significant development this year came when co-founder Morgan Lloyd began converting archival records into visual representations. By accessing William Still's Underground Railroad documentation of Freedom Seekers arriving in Philadelphia, Lloyd uses AI to generate images, then shares them on Instagram on the anniversary dates of those arrivals.

The 1838 Black Metropolis represented an existential challenge to slave-holding interests located roughly 100 miles south. With approximately 20,000 free Black residents establishing institutions, accumulating wealth, forming global networks, and providing refuge for Freedom Seekers, the community directly contradicted enslavers' pseudo-scientific racial justifications. Multiple violent campaigns targeted this community during the 1830s and 1840s.

Attacks on The Black Metropolis

The 1834 attack—nicknamed "Flying Horses" because violence began at a carousel located at 7th and South streets—sparked investigation into victim records. Stephen James, age 50 and married with two children, became a focal point of this research. While city directories and census data omitted him, Penn Hospital admission records documented his presence.

Hospital records from 1834 reveal that in August specifically, 100 percent of admitted Black patients showed cuts and fractures with no documented diseases, suggesting mob violence rather than illness. Among the 67 Black people admitted that year:

- Issac Christian**, 40, married. Admitted August 13 with "wounded scalp" from "recent accident"; released August 14.
- Stephen James**, 50, married. Admitted August 14 with "injured head" from "recent accident"; died August 24.
- Joseph Sebastian**, 23, married. Admitted August 19 with "fractured skull" from "recent accident"; released August 23.

Records document that James was beaten to death in front of his wife and children on Baker Street (now Pemberton). Abolitionist Edwin Abdy visited the death site and recorded observations published in contemporary accounts.

The characterization as a "race riot" misrepresents what actually occurred—four days of coordinated attacks on Black institutions, homes, and families, not spontaneous uprising. Contemporary reports described organized white participants in matching clothing, pre-arranged signals (candles in windows), planned meeting locations, and leaders explicitly instructing followers to "hunt" community members with maximum violence.

1842 Mob Attack Victims

The subsequent 1842 attack, termed the "Lombard Street Riot," similarly suffered from mischaracterization. The prevailing narrative attributes violence to Irish-Black labor competition, yet historical evidence reveals attacks targeted Black wealth, institutions, homes—not labor sites. The violence coincided with a temperance and abolition parade organized by young people's groups on West Indian Emancipation Day, August 1.

Crucially, 1842 Penn Hospital admission records explicitly documented cause: "Injured by a Mob." Hospital staff appeared intentionally creating a restorative justice record.

Victims admitted August 1, 1842:

- John Robins**, 23. Wound of scalp.
- Peter Robins**, 17. Wound of scalp and contusions.
- Charles Black**, 48. Laceration wound of scalp.
- Charles Black, Jr.**, 14. Contusions and wound of scalp.
- Joseph Hood**, 22. Wound of scalp and contusions.
- George Mason**, 34. Wound of scalp and contusions.
- George Wilkes**, 25. Wound of scalp and contusions.
- Louisa Wilkes**, 22. Injuries documented.

James Fetterman, 47. Injuries documented.

William Quastine, 28. Injuries documented.

Isaac Reed, 65. Injuries documented.

Frances Draper, 30. Injuries documented.

William Ridgely, 20. Injuries documented.

The hospital's admitting clerk eventually abbreviated repeated entries as "do" (ditto), suggesting overwhelming patient volume. Youth participation stemmed from their involvement in temperance and abolition organizing through groups like the Wesley Sabbath School.

Temperance Movement Context

The American Moral Reform Society promoted sobriety and substance abstinence throughout the 1838 Black Metropolis. By 1842, their success in helping community members achieve and maintain sobriety created significantly reduced revenue streams for rum sellers. A letter to the editor in The Liberator attributed the parade attack partly to "diminished revenue of rum sellers."

This represents an overlooked historical achievement: "a successful Black led and run movement to help people get and stay clean" operating decades earlier than commonly recognized.

Conceptual Reframing

The language used to describe these events matters substantially. Rather than "race riots," these were coordinated mob attacks on innocent people. Black residents were not rioting—they were targeted. White mobs possessed organizational structure and planning, not spontaneous anger. The appropriate framing centers vulnerable community members attempting to build sanctuary spaces for families.

Learn More

Emma Lapsansky-Werner's scholarship examines whether "elements endemic to the creation or existence of certain institutions...contributed to whites' selection of these institutions as targets for destruction?"

John Runcie's research details mob composition and motivations.

Andrew Crocco's thesis argues attacks were "coordinated over years" with "ultimate goal to move Black people out of the city center."

Images

- Stephen James family visualization — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/f61430_92dd741dfcd84ad39e50114a20346016~mv2.png
- Penn Hospital admittance book excerpt — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/f61430_38200c21ad994da5ae56347209eda6b8~mv2.png
- August 1, 1842 admissions record — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/f61430_886752d5235f402bb8d442ccd65f855e~mv2.jpg
- Wesley Sabbath School children parade participation — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/f61430_a8c98202796f46299654252353c0f728~mv2.png
- Letter to Jacob C. White regarding parade organization — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/f61430_d7cd3414fd2b41dfba5abe1bc2638b80~mv2.jpg
- Letter to editor from The Liberator — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/f61430_dacb496a410542e880f9f36c05ae881f~mv2.png
- Edwin Abdy historical account excerpt — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/f61430_0a35863530534477935e241db63bea5b~mv2.png and https://static.wixstatic.com/media/f61430_702ef665d87c416fadde6d44bb203f12~mv2.png

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